The Attack

By Yasmina Khadra

INTRODUCTION

The mind of a religious terrorist is difficult for a Western person to comprehend. What could lead a person to cause his or her own violent death is a question that is frequently raised. It is contrary to every human emotion that we have. Yet, we know there are hundreds of Islamic fundamentalists who are willing to kill and be killed for Allah. All over the world, in Kenya, Algeria, Indonesia, Egypt, Iran, France, South America and America, terrorists have attacked and murdered those they felt were a threat to their religious aims. No one has been spared. "The Attack" by Yasmina Khadra portrays the individual reality of terrorism and its incalculable spiritual costs.

I don't remember hearing an explosion. A hissing sound, maybe, like tearing fabric, but I'm not certain. My attention was distracted by that quasi-divinity and the host of devoted followers surrounding him as his bodyguards tried to clear a passage to his waiting automobile. "Let us pass, please. Please move out of the way." The faithful elbowed one another, hoping to get a better look at the sheikh or touch a part of his "kamis." From time to time,

4NG Fanatics

the revered old man turned to greet an acquaintance or thank a disciple. The eyes in his ascetic's face glinted like the blade of a scimitar.

I was being crushed by the enraptured throng and tried in vain to break free. The sheikh plunged into his vehicle, waving with one hand from behind the bulletproof glass while his two bodyguards took their places on either side of him. And then...but there's nothing more. Something resembling a lightning bolt streaks across the sky and bursts like a giant flare in the middle of the roadway; the shock wave strikes me full force; the crowd whose frenzy held me captive disintegrates. In a fraction of a second, the sky collapses, and the street, fraught with the fervor of the multitude a moment ago, turns upside down. The body of a man, or perhaps a boy, hurtles across my vertiginous sight like a dark flash. What's going on? A surge of dust and fire envelops me, flinging me into the air with a thousand other projectiles. I have a vague sensation of being reduced to shreds, of dissolving in the blast's hot breath...

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

A few yards--or light-years--away, the sheikh's automobile is ablaze. Hungry tentacles enclose it, spreading abroad a dreadful odor of cremation. The roar of the flames must be terrifying; I can't hear it. I've been struck deaf, ravished away from the noises of the town. I hear nothing, I feel nothing; I hover, I only hover. I hover for an eternity before plunging back to earth, stunned, undone, but curiously lucid, my eyes wide open on the horror that has just descended on the town from out of the sky. In the instant when I touch the ground, everything freezes: the flames rising above the destroyed vehicle, the flying projectiles, the smoke, the chaos, the smells, time....Only a heavenly voice, floating over the fathomless silence of death, is singing "One of these days, we'll go back home." It's not exactly a voice; it's more like a rustling, a filigree of sound....My head bounces off something....

A child cries: "Mama!" The call is weak, but distinct and pure. It comes from far away, from some calm elsewhere....The flames devouring the sheikh's car refuse to budge; the projectiles won't fall....My hand gropes among the gravel. I believe I've been hurt. I try to move my legs, to lift my head; not one of my muscles obeys me....

4NG Fanatics

"Mama," the child cries...."I'm over here, Amin...." And there she is, Mama, emerging from behind a curtain of smoke. She advances through the suspended debris, amid petrified gestures, past mouths opened upon the abyss. For a moment, because of her milk white veil and her tormented look, I take her for the Virgin. My mother was always like this, radiant and sad at the same time, like a candle.

When she placed her hand on my burning forehead, she took away all my fever and all my cares....And now "she's here;" her magic powers are still intact. A shudder runs through me from my feet to my head, setting everything free and unleashing delirium. The flames start their macabre movement again, the exploded fragments resume their trajectories, and panic comes flooding back in....

A man in rags, with blackened face and arms, tries to approach the blazing automobile. Although he's gravely wounded, some reserve of stubbornness moves him to try to help the sheikh, no matter what the cost. Every time he puts his hand on the door of the car, a jet of flames drives him back. Inside the blasted vehicle, the trapped bodies are

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

burning. Two blood-covered specters approach from the other side and try to force open the rear door. I see them screaming orders or crying out in pain, but I don't hear them. Not far from where I'm lying, an old man stares at me stupidly; he doesn't seem to realize his guts are exposed to the air and his blood is streaming toward the crater in the street. A wounded man with an enormous smoking stain on his back is crawling across the rubble. He passes quite close to me, groaning and panic-stricken, and gives up the ghost a little farther on, his eyes wide open, as if he's still denying that such a thing could happen to him, to "him." The two specters finally break the windshield and dive into the automobile.

Other survivors come to their aid. With their bare hands, they pull apart the flaming vehicle, break the windows, tear off the doors, and succeed in extracting the sheikh's body. A dozen arms lift him up, carry him away from the inferno, and lay him down on the sidewalk, while a flurry of other hands strives to beat the fire out of his clothes. A deep, intense tingling makes its presence felt in my hip. My trousers have almost disappeared; only a few strips of scorched cloth cover me here and there. Against

4NG Fanatics

my side, grotesque and horrible, my leg is lying, still connected to my thigh by a thin ribbon of flesh. Suddenly, all my strength deserts me. I have the sensation that my fibers are separating from one another, already decomposing....

At last, I hear something, the wailing of an ambulance, and little by little, the noises of the street return, break over me like waves, stun me. Someone bends over my body, gives it a summary examination with his stethoscope, and goes away. I see him stoop before a heap of charred flesh, take its pulse, and then make a sign to some stretcher-bearers. A man comes to me, picks up my wrist, and lets it fall again...."This one's a goner. We can't do anything for him." I'd like to hold him back and force him to reconsider his assessment, but my arm mutinies, refusing to obey me.

The child starts crying out again: "Mama...." I look for my mother amid the chaos...and discover only orchards, stretching as far as I can see...Grandfather's orchards...the orchards of the patriarch...a land of orange trees, where every day was summer...and a dreaming boy on the crest of a hill. The sky is a limpid blue. Everywhere, the orange trees

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

are holding out their arms to one another. The child is twelve years old, with a porcelain heart. At his age, there's so much to love at first sight, and simply because his trust runs as deep as his joy, he thinks of devouring the moon like a fruit, convinced that he need only reach out his hand to gather up the happiness of all the world....And there, before my eyes, despite the tragedy that has just ruined forever My memory of that distant day, despite the bodies of the dying scattered in the street and the flames that have now completely overwhelmed the sheikh's automobile, the boy bounds to his feet, his arms spread like a kestrel's wings, and goes running across the fields, where every tree is enchanted....

Tears furrow my cheeks...."Whoever told you a man mustn't cry doesn't know what it means to he a man," my father declared when he came upon me, weeping and distraught, in the patriarch's funeral chamber. "There's no shame in crying, my boy. Tears are the noblest things we have." Since I refused to release Grandfather's hand, my father knelt before me and took me in his arms. "There's no use staying here," he said. "The dead are dead, they're

4NG Fanatics

over, they've served their time. As for the living, they're ghosts, too; they're just early for their appointment...."

Two bearers pick me up and put me on a stretcher. An ambulance backs up to us, its rear doors wide open. Arms pull me inside and practically throw me among some other corpses. In my final throes, I hear myself sob.... "God, if this is some horrible nightmare, let me wake up, and soon...."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Yasmina Khadra
ISBN: 978-0385517485
Publisher: Nan A. Talese.
Date (Month/Year): May 2006

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY